Karl Friedrich Neumann — Eliše, the Martyrology (History of Vartan, Chapter 8)

The Boneyard is a collection of works left unfinished, unpublished, or unread at their authors' deaths — dry bones in the valley, in Ezekiel's image. Each presentation tells the scholar's story, weighs what survives of his work, and states plainly what completing it would take, so that a book the world never received whole can be met at last. Each of them was one of one. There will never be another like him, and his light will not shine again except through the work he left behind.

A Boneyard dossier — researched and presented by Robert Tilford, Hays, Kansas. Filed 17 October 2026.

Disclosure: prepared with AI assistance — the six subject reviewers named in the index are AI agents, each desk-checked at this desk; all rulings and final decisions are the author's own.

Dedication

To Karl Friedrich Neumann, who learned Armenian at San Lazzaro, carried Eliše into English in 1830, and left the Martyrology for a second volume that never came.

The story

Neumann was born at Reichmannsdorf, son of the Jewish trader Lippmann Bamberger. No settled birth date is printed here: the *Neue Deutsche Biographie* gives 28 December 1793, itself uncertain — the synagogue record was destroyed at his conversion in 1818 — while the *Jewish Encyclopedia* gives 1798. He reached Heidelberg in 1817; in 1818 he converted to Protestantism at Munich and took the name Neumann.

He taught at gymnasia from 1821 to 1825 and was dismissed, or placed in quiescence, for rationalistic biblical exegesis. He learned Armenian at San Lazzaro and studied in Paris under Rémusat, who carried him into the Royal Asiatic Society and the Oriental Translation Fund's list in 1829. From China he brought back over 12,000 volumes, most given to Bavaria, and became professor at Munich (1832–33). Removed in 1852 under pressure from the

Freising bishops' conference, he died at Berlin on 17 March 1870.

Eliše, called vartabed, or doctor, is carried by the *Catholic Encyclopedia* as a fifth-century historian, companion of Vartan in the war of 449–451 against Yazkert II; his *History* is counted a masterpiece of ancient Armenian literature. Modern scholarship dates the work later.

The work and what survives

Neumann's *History of Vartan* (London: Oriental Translation Fund, 1830) deliberately omitted this chapter: in his preface the priests' sufferings “forms a small work by itself,” deferred to his Lazarus of Pharp; the second volume never appeared. Eliše promises seven chapters; every edition appends an eighth, on the Leontian martyrs, whose genuineness has been questioned. The folder's front matter claims the deferred labour “is here, at last, done.” The collation corrects that claim.

A condensed English rendering of the Martyrology (Eliše, *History of Vartan*, chapter 8), retelling the chapter's episodes in about one quarter of the length of the Venice 1859 Armenian text, printed pp. 110–158. It is not a complete translation of chapter 8.

That is the folder's holding: a condensed English retelling, not a complete translation, retold in English from the Armenian. The rendering counts 3,312 English words; the whole file 3,814, including 502 of front matter. Its sections: main narrative 1,833; Samuel and Abraham 352; Release of the Princes 644; Wives 348; Conclusion 135. The source span was verified in the scan — chapter heading before the printed page 111 header, running head “Eighth Chapter,” ՎԵՐՋ (End) on page 158 — 49 printed pages. Sampling estimates about 250–350 Armenian words a page, about 12,250–17,150 words, making the rendering about one quarter (19–27 per cent). No ellipses or abridgement marks exist in the file; the condensation is nowhere marked.

The opening (pp. 110–111) matches in substance. Pages 111–114 — Samuel and Abraham in the caravan, Nenshapuh's charge, forty days in a dark inner prison, fifteen days of secret food-bearers, the chief magus's long discourse — are compressed away or reordered. Leontius's sun disputation runs at least pp. 127–132 against about 267 folder words. The wives passage (pp. 156–158)

follows the source motif by motif — the strongest correspondence — but compressed; the preceding plunder lament is absent entirely, and the 135-word Conclusion had no counterpart identifiable on the final page (at OCR strength). One slip shows the haste: the martyrs are “seven in number, counting also the magus,” followed by seven names, none the magus.

Its English fortunes

The folder's “first free English rendering” survives, if at all, only as a first free condensed rendering, attributed to the folder, with no hardened primacy check behind it.

Beside it stand Boyadjian's unabridged edition (1952) and Thomson's *History of Vardan and the Armenian War* (Harvard University Press, 1982, ISBN 0674403355), from the critical text. The collation used Thomson for contents and scale only and did not open his chapter 8 text. Neumann's own 1830 English is public domain but unfinished and abridged, with none of the Martyrology.

What completing it would take

A true complete translation of chapter 8 from the Venice 1859 Armenian — all 49 printed pages. The honest alternative: the retelling relabelled at its true scope wherever shelved, as a condensed English retelling, not a complete translation. Any “first free” wording stands unqualified only after a hardened primacy check.

Sources

- Project folder: `~/workspace/rare-and-obscure-books/books/neumann-elise-martyrology/neumann-elise-martyrology.txt`
- PIN and collation: `~/workspace/packages/boneyard-extension/research/PIN-neumann-elise.md`; `~/workspace/packages/boneyard-extension/research/NEUMANN-COLLATION.md`
- Deutsche Biographie (NDB 19): https://www.deutsche-biographie.de/gnd116962259.html?language=en
- *Catholic Encyclopedia*, “Elishé”: https://www.studylight.org/

encyclopedias/eng/tce/e/elisheacute.html

- Venice 1859 Eliše, *Writings*, Internet Archive: https://archive.org/details/EghisheMatenagrutiwnk
- Thomson 1982 record (ISBN 0674403355): https://www.abebooks.com/9780674403352/History-Vardan-Armenian-Harvard-Texts-0674403355/plp